BIHARI COLLECTION

NO. 06



BIHAR ORIGIN

Chana Ghugni

Spiced Dried Chickpea Curry

Bihar's Beloved Street Food Snack

AUTHENTIC RECIPE · STEP-BY-STEP GUIDE · PRINTABLE DIGITAL COOKBOOK

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Chana Ghugni

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Contact: support@dhaniodigital.com

ABOUT THIS BOOK

Chana Ghugni

AUTHOR

Sweta Verma

PUBLISHER

DhanioDigital

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DISCLAIMER

Nutrition values are estimates. Cooking times vary with equipment and ingredients. Readers with allergies or dietary restrictions should check every ingredient label before cooking.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

The Snack That Fuels a Roadside Economy

Chana ghugni belongs to a category of dried legume snacks found in various forms across eastern India, and in Bihar it takes shape as a comforting, tangy stew of dried chickpeas or a smaller brown variety of chana, slow-cooked with warm spices until tender and lightly thickened. It's a dish deeply woven into the rhythm of everyday Bihari street life — sold from carts and roadside stalls throughout the day, from breakfast through evening, often topped with raw onion, a squeeze of lemon, and served with puffed rice (muri) on the side.

Its accessibility and affordability have made ghugni a genuine street food institution, the kind of snack that cuts across class lines in a way few other dishes do — enjoyed equally by laborers grabbing a quick, filling bite and office workers looking for an afternoon snack. Vendors often develop loyal followings based on their particular spice blend and technique, with certain ghugni carts becoming local landmarks in their own right.

While it thrives as street food, chana ghugni is just as commonly made at home, particularly as a quick, protein-rich breakfast or snack that requires only dried chickpeas and pantry spices — a practical dish that has earned its widespread popularity through genuine everyday usefulness rather than any elaborate technique.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

The Snack That Fuels a Roadside Economy, continued

CULTURAL NOTES & OCCASIONS

A ubiquitous Bihari street food, sold from carts and stalls throughout the day across the state. Enjoys popularity across social and economic lines, valued equally as a quick snack by laborers and office workers alike. Traditionally topped with raw onion, lemon, and served alongside puffed rice (muri) for texture. Equally common as a home-cooked breakfast or snack, requiring only pantry-friendly dried legumes and spices.

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AT A GLANCE

Equipment & preparation

15m	8h + 40m	4	Easy
ACTIVE PREP	SOAK + COOK TIME	SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

Recommended equipment

- Pressure cooker
- Kadai or wide pan
- Wooden spoon

STORAGE & MAKE-AHEAD

Chana ghugni keeps refrigerated for up to 4 days and, like many legume-based dishes, tastes good even better the next day. It freezes well for up to 3 months, making it a practical make-ahead snack or light meal.

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients

For the ghugni

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Dried brown chickpeas (kala chana) or white chickpeas	1½ cups	300 g	1½ katori
Water, for soaking and cooking	as needed	as needed	as needed
Bay leaf	1	1	1
Salt	1 tsp	6 g	to taste

For the masala

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Mustard oil	3 tbsp	45 ml	3 chammach
Cumin seeds	1 tsp	4 g	1 chammach
Onion, finely chopped	1 medium	100 g	1 medium
Ginger-garlic paste	1 tbsp	15 g	1 chammach
Tomato, chopped	1 medium	100 g	1 medium
Turmeric powder	½ tsp	1.5 g	½ chammach
Coriander powder	1 tsp	3 g	1 chammach
Red chili powder	½ tsp	1.5 g	½ chammach
Garam masala	½ tsp	1.5 g	½ chammach
Salt	to taste	to taste	to taste

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients, continued

For garnish

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Onion, finely chopped	¼ cup	30 g	¼ katori
Green chili, chopped	1	1	1
Fresh coriander, chopped	2 tbsp	8 g	2 tbsp
Lemon wedges	4	4	4
Puffed rice (muri) — optional	1 cup	20 g	1 katori

SUBSTITUTIONS & SOURCING

Both kala chana (small brown chickpeas) and regular white chickpeas work well for this dish; kala chana has a slightly earthier flavor and firmer texture, closer to the traditional street-cart version. Canned chickpeas can shortcut the process, using two 15 oz / 400 g cans, drained and rinsed, with the initial soaking and boiling steps skipped. Puffed rice, sold as "muri" or "murmura" at Indian grocers, is a traditional textural addition but can be omitted if unavailable.

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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Cooking the Chickpeas

01 SOAK OVERNIGHT

Rinse the dried chickpeas and soak in plenty of water overnight, or at least 8 hours.

02 PRESSURE COOK UNTIL SOFT

Drain and pressure cook with fresh water, the bay leaf, and salt for 6–8 whistles (kala chana may need slightly longer), until completely soft.



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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Cooking the Chickpeas, continued

Chef tip. keep the chickpea cooking liquid — it's useful for adjusting the final consistency of the ghugni.

COOKING CHECKPOINT

The chickpeas are ready when they mash easily under light pressure between two fingers, with no firm or chalky centers remaining.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Building the Masala

03 BLOOM THE CUMIN

Heat mustard oil in a kadai and add the cumin seeds, letting them sizzle for a few seconds until fragrant.

04 SAUTÉ THE ONIONS

Add the chopped onion and sauté until golden, about 7–8 minutes. Stir in the ginger-garlic paste, cooking until fragrant.

05 ADD TOMATO AND SPICES

Add the chopped tomato, turmeric, coriander powder, and chili powder. Cook for 6–8 minutes, until the tomato breaks down and the oil separates slightly at the edges.

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Building the Masala, continued



06 COMBINE WITH THE CHICKPEAS

Add the cooked chickpeas to the masala, along with some reserved cooking liquid to reach a thick, slightly saucy consistency. Simmer for 10–15 minutes, mashing a few chickpeas against the pan to help thicken naturally. Finish with garam masala.

Texture indicator. ghugni should be thick enough to hold its shape on a spoon, not thin or soupy, with some whole chickpeas and some broken down for body.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Building the Masala, continued

MISTAKE TO AVOID

Serving the chickpeas right after cooking without properly simmering them in the masala misses the depth this dish is known for. Give the combined mixture at least 10–15 minutes together for the flavors to fully meld.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve



Traditional Style

- Served in a bowl topped with raw onion, green chili, coriander, and a generous squeeze of lemon, with puffed rice on the side.
- A classic street food snack, enjoyed any time of day from roadside carts across Bihar.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve, continued

Family Style

- A quick, protein-rich breakfast or snack at home, garnished fresh and served warm.

Modern Pairing

- Works well as a hearty, protein-forward salad topping or a filling for wraps.

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RESTAURANT-GRADE TRICKS

Chef secrets

Getting the Flavor Right

- Mashing a portion of the chickpeas into the masala thickens the dish naturally and gives it its characteristic hearty texture.
- Fresh garnishes — raw onion, lemon, and coriander — added just before serving are essential to the dish's bright, street-food character.

Make-Ahead & Meal Prep

- Ghugni is an excellent make-ahead dish, improving in flavor after a day in the refrigerator.
- Cook a large batch of chickpeas and freeze in portions, making the masala fresh each time for a quick meal.

RESTAURANT TRICK

Street vendors often keep a large pot simmering gently all day, letting the flavors deepen continuously — replicate this at home by making the dish a day ahead and reheating gently before serving.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ

APPROXIMATE NUTRITION, PER SERVING

230 kcal	11 g	32 g	7 g	9 g
CALORIES	PROTEIN	CARBOHYDRATES	FAT	FIBER

Estimates only; actual values vary with oil and portion size.

ALLERGEN GUIDE

Contains, based on the ingredient list: Mustard. Check packaged spices and asafoetida, which may contain wheat, and verify against your own ingredients.

REGIONAL VARIATIONS

Kala Chana Ghugni	the earthier, firmer-textured version using small brown chickpeas, closer to the classic street-cart style.
Ghugni Chaat	dressed up with chutneys, sev, and yogurt for a more elaborate chaat-style presentation.
Dry Ghugni	a less saucy version, cooked down further for a drier, snackable texture.

Can I use canned chickpeas?

Yes — use two 15 oz / 400 g cans, drained and rinsed, skipping the soaking and reducing the simmering time since they're already tender.

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Nutrition, variations & FAQ, continued

What's the difference between kala chana and regular chickpeas here?

Kala chana (brown chickpeas) have a firmer texture and earthier flavor, considered more traditional for this specific dish, though white chickpeas work well too.

Is chana ghugni served hot or cold?

It's traditionally served warm, though leftovers are also perfectly enjoyable at room temperature as a quick snack.

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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary



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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary, continued

GLOSSARY

Ghugni	a spiced dried chickpea curry, a beloved Bihari street food snack.
Muri	Bihar/Bengali for puffed rice, traditionally served alongside ghugni for texture.
Kala Chana	small brown chickpeas, a traditional choice for this dish.
Chaat	a broad category of Indian savory snacks, often featuring tangy and spiced toppings.

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PRINTABLE RECIPE CARD

Chana Ghugni

15m	8h + 40m
ACTIVE PREP	SOAK + COOK TIME
4	**Easy**
SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

GHUGNI

Dried brown chickpeas	300 g
Water	as needed
Bay leaf	1
Salt	6 g

MASALA

Mustard oil	45 ml
Cumin seeds	4 g
Onion	100 g
Ginger-garlic paste	15 g
Tomato	100 g
Turmeric powder	1.5 g
Coriander powder	3 g
Red chili powder	1.5 g
Garam masala	1.5 g
Salt	to taste

FOR GARNISH

Onion	30 g
Green chili	1
Fresh coriander	8 g
Lemon wedges	4
Puffed rice	20 g

METHOD

01 **Soak overnight.** Rinse the dried chickpeas and soak in plenty of water overnight, or at least 8 hours.

02 **Pressure cook until soft.** Drain and pressure cook with fresh water, the bay leaf, and salt for 6–8 whistles (kala chana may need slightly longer), until completely soft.

03 **Bloom the cumin.** Heat mustard oil in a kadai and add the cumin seeds, letting them sizzle for a few seconds until fragrant.

04 **Sauté the onions.** Add the chopped onion and sauté until golden, about 7–8 minutes.

05 **Add tomato and spices.** Add the chopped tomato, turmeric, coriander powder, and chili powder.

06 **Combine with the chickpeas.** Add the cooked chickpeas to the masala, along with some reserved cooking liquid to reach a thick, slightly saucy consistency.

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BEFORE YOU SHOP

Shopping list

☐ Dried brown chickpeas	300 g	☐ Bay leaf	1
☐ Salt	see recipe	☐ Mustard oil	45 ml
☐ Cumin seeds	4 g	☐ Onion	see recipe
☐ Ginger-garlic paste	15 g	☐ Tomato	100 g
☐ Turmeric powder	1.5 g	☐ Coriander powder	3 g
☐ Red chili powder	1.5 g	☐ Garam masala	1.5 g
☐ Green chili	1	☐ Fresh coriander	8 g
☐ Lemon wedges	4	☐ Puffed rice	20 g

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